

Of Import duties

LG recently announced that it plans to stop manufacturing mobile phones at a facility it operates in Mexicali, Mexico, near the California border. The plant there makes some 200,000 phones per month and has about 200 employees. LG is making the change due to an import tariff no longer being in place that cost LG 15% to import devices into Mexico

knack of it after even 8-10 hours of use. The jog dial also has four distinct click points that can be used to move up and down or

sideways and the centre button also incorporates a tiny screen that will display an icon for any option you select. This method of navigation (using the directional buttons) is better than the dial method and we found navigation a snap.

The screen is clear and the fonts are really crisp. The phone has a basic camera that does what it's supposed to and offers acceptable quality. Music playback is good and the handsfree offers good quality. Sadly this phone seems to have a weak battery rated at only 800 mAh and we found that the vibration system, coupled with the extra lighting drained the battery very fast. Call quality could have been better, especially in regions of lower signal strength. Priced at Rs. 11,990 the KM710 is a fine looking phone with a nifty, functional navigation system. However it's also a little pricey, mainly because of the flashy features that some might find unnecessary. If you are inclined towards a flashy cellphone this isn't a bad idea. If you want functionality and a larger screen, this isn't worth your time.

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HTC Touch Viva

This handset is fully plastic with a glossy finish. While the quality of materials used is far from top class it's built well and the surface treatment looks like it will stand some wear. The dark grey body has a silver ring around the sides of the phone, giving it a classy look, as does the raised chrome rim around the centre button that also acts as directional navigation.

The call buttons are vertically stacked and small and thin. However they're easy to use since there aren't other buttons in close proximity. The volume up/down button is little more than a thin slash amidst the silver bezel on the side but owing to its raised edge and superb feedback, it is really usable.

The stylus is solid metal except for the retention on one end and its tip. Going by the trend, even the power button is a tiny slash and easily missed at first glance. The USB port is also used for the headset; once again proprietary connects are used.

Our first and one of our major gripes are with the glossiness of the display – when held at eye level you can see your face in it. This is a pain to be sure. Display quality is decent but should be much better and the fonts used do not seem as high resolution as they should be. Colours also seem a little faded out. The phone's interface is fast enough for most tasks but will lag when opening the camera. Since it lacks a hardware keypad we had to make do with the onscreen affair that was a poor substitute for the real thing but much better than the onscreen keypads of the previous touchscreen phones. The camera is pretty useless and makes do without even an autofocus or a flash unit. Call quality was good, better than expected and the earpiece volume is also quite good. The handsfree unit gives decent quality when on a call, but falls short of praise when listening to music. This phone has Wi-Fi which will be of interest to those interested in using it to surf and is the cheapest phone available with this feature.



HTC Touch Viva

Motorola ROKR E8

Another sexy looker from Motorola with a glossy fascia built out of a single piece of transparent fibre. In fact with the screen and keypad lighting switched off the ROKR E8 looks like something that just walked off a Milan catwalk. The rear is not so exotic and is metal with a rubberised surface coating. The number keys have a very tiny raised dimple to indicate that your finger is indeed on top of a key and this is the only way to discern between keys. The key layout is spaced and well done, but key feedback is not at all positive and key travel is minimal – something Motorola does a lot on their phones. The black shiny surface has a chrome slash in the form of the joypad and even this fits flush in the phone such that the entire top is on one plane. The menu buttons are well laid out as are the call buttons. Backlighting is slightly excessive, although it tends to get dim in daylight. The phone itself is wide but not thick. Needless to say build quality is really good thanks to the metal rear. We'd like the screen to have been larger, but two inches is all we got.

Although the ROKR E8 has mediocre in-call quality, it's a good music player. The bundled earphones are also good and the 3.5-mm jack is a plus. The measly support for audio and video formats is a minus though.

At Rs. 13,999 the ROKR E8 is a super swanky looking phone that offers a fair amount of features. It's a really neat looking phone that Motorola fans will really appreciate and others will admire. But for the features and performance

we feel it's overpriced. The Abhishek Bachan advertisement for the ROKR series notwithstanding, we recommend that you wait for price drops or look elsewhere for your groove.

HTC Touch Diamond

The Diamond looks like an HTC Touch Pro on a severe diet. It misses out on the hardware QWERTY and has a smaller battery which is why it's slimmer and a lot lighter. The rear seems to be more solid and is finished in glossy black but a look at the front face and you cannot tell the Diamond and the Pro apart. The name Diamond comes from the sculpted rear that

has been cut at various angles to give the appearance of many sides – like its namesake. Build quality is good and the Touch Diamond looks clean. It has 4 GB of internal storage but no expansion. The screen is a little devoid of colours but bright and crisp enough. Fonts are clearer than on the Touch Viva, although not the best around.

Once again the lack of a dedicated keyboard cannot be made up for by the onscreen one, simply because of the prohibitively small screen size. The call buttons are touch activated and very well laid out and amply backlit, while the home and back button also aid navigation. In fact most other non-HTC devices do not have a back

button and we feel this is a nifty and very utilitarian feature that is simple to implement and should be standardised on all WM devices.

The camera on this phone is decent, actually a lot better than we expected; it outperforms some of the other 3.2 megapixel units in this test. The antenna is of mediocre quality and we had

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Motorola ROKR E8